



High hopes: As the PKL 11 caravan moves to Pune for its third and final leg, Ajit Chouhan (in orange jersey) has expressed his desire to lead his team to a championship victory at home. PKL

kabaddi, so in seventh grade, he joined them and never looked back.

"Initially, I just wanted to play with my friends, but then I started to have fun. With time, I became more serious about the sport and got selected for the academy," recalls Ajit to *Sportstar*.

Initially a left-corner defender, Ajit transitioned into a raider at the SAI Sports Academy in Thergaon, leveraging his kickboxing skills to enhance his lower body strength and agility.

His rapid development caught the attention of state coaches, leading to his selection for the 2021 Junior Nationals in Haridwar. His impressive performance at the 2022 Khelo India Youth Games, where Maharashtra secured third place, caught the eye of the PKL franchise Gujarat Giants. Unfortunately, he was unable to make it to the final squad due to age restrictions.

Despite his release from the Gujarat team, Ajit remained undeterred. He intensified his training regimen and guided Pune to victory in the Maharashtra inter-state tournament earlier this year. His impressive performances in the tournament attracted the attention of Mumbai's scouts, who subsequently drafted him into their squad.

For Ajit, it felt like a homecoming. As an aspiring kabaddi player in Maharashtra, he had long admired the legendary Anup Kumar, the former Indian captain and the pivotal figure in U Mumba's lone PKL title victory in the second edition.

"Anup sir is a legend. He's my idol. His quick thinking and movements inspired me while I was training to become a raider. When I joined the U Mumba team, it felt like I had come

home," says the youngster.

After a rigorous pre-season camp under the watchful eye of Mumba's Iranian head coach, Gholamreza Mazandarani, Ajit finally got the chance to go on the PKL mat.

When the moment finally arrived against Dabang Delhi in the second match of PKL 11, it was a whirlwind experience. The young raider, still in disbelief, couldn't fathom how he had managed to score 10 raid points.

"The stadium was full, the lighting was changing, like a carnival. The noise was deafening, I couldn't understand anything. I just played my game, and after a few games, I started to feel comfortable," he opined.

One of the standout features of Ajit's game is his sudden acceleration and power. His languid approach belies his sudden bursts of speed, catching defenders off guard. He often targets the opposition's top defenders, particularly the left-corners.

"The plan is to attack the top defender and send them to the bench. The more time they spend on the bench, the better for us to accumulate points," he explains.

Hurdles to overcome

However, it has not been a smooth campaign for the burly raider, who hasn't been consistent. After a brilliant start, he has somewhat fizzled out. In the match against Telugu Titans, he was substituted after attempting six unsuccessful raids.

There are concerns about his ability to use his upper body to power through defenders effectively. He has struggled to score points against four or fewer defenders. Specifically, the technique of pushing defenders deep seems to be lacking in his game. The surprise element he brought for defenders has now diminished, and teams have started to plan for him.

Ajit is aware of the situation and is working on his skills with his coaches. He acknowledges that he has a long way to go and needs to improve his game.

As the PKL 11 caravan moves to Pune for its third and final leg, the Pune-born raider has expressed his desire to lead his team to a championship victory on home soil. While individual milestones are secondary, he has set a challenge for himself.

"My only goal is to help my team go all the way and lift the trophy in my hometown Pune. There is no such personal goal, but I would like to get more than 200 raid points in the season. It will be a big morale booster for me and will also be beneficial for the team," Ajit concludes.



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